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Edward Wiles

edward [dot] m [dot] wiles [at] gmail [dot] com

Academic Positions

Postdoctoral Academy Scholar, Harvard Academy for International and Area Studies 2025-2027

Education

PhD Economics, Massachusetts Institute of Technology 2019-2025
MSc Economics, London School of Economics 2017-2018
BSc Economics, London School of Economics 2012-2015

Research Statement

I am a trade and development economist studying how firms manage exchange in the presence of contracting frictions, and how these micro-level responses shape the structure and behavior of supply chains and aggregate economic outcomes. I use a combination of quantitative models, administrative data, and field experiments to study how firms and organizations find suppliers, obtain trade credit, screen workers, and adapt to institutional constraints. A common theme is that the dynamic process of relationship-building plays a key role when contracts are costly to enforce, which has consequences for the nature and speed of economic growth and development.

Working Papers

Aggregate Consequences of Relationship Dynamics in Trade (with Pulak Ghosh)

Most trade takes place within long-term buyer-seller relationships whose value reflects past experience and, when contract enforcement is limited, the expectation of future business. We study how these relationship dynamics shape aggregate adjustment to changes in trade costs. We develop a dynamic multi-location, multi-sector Ricardian model with relationship-specific learning and relational contracts. Accumulated relationship value slows adjustment as some firms retain incumbent suppliers despite cheaper alternatives, while improved outside options can offset this by undermining the incentives needed to sustain those relationships. A property of the optimal contract that we call scale equivariance permits tractable aggregation of these micro-level dynamics. Using rich firm-to-firm transaction data from India, we establish that proportional growth within relationships is remarkably similar across firm characteristics and experience—supportive of the scale equivariance property—and varies with contract enforcement. We use these empirical results as moments to estimate the model's learning and contracting parameters, and study a reduction in interstate trade costs calibrated to a major Indian domestic integration reform. Both dynamic mechanisms are quantitatively important: it takes 15 quarters for the economy to reach 90% of its long-run trade elasticity, compared with 30 quarters when relationships can continue even if their contracts violate the post-shock incentive constraint.

Relational Frictions along the Supply Chain: Evidence from Senegalese Traders (with Deivy Houeix)

We study search and trust frictions in international sourcing, and whether the rapid growth of "social commerce" in lower-income countries can alleviate them. Guided by a dynamic model of relational contracting, we run a field experiment with 1,862 garment firms in Senegal, randomly matching them to suppliers in Türkiye (search) and varying information about supplier type (adverse selection) and incentives (moral hazard). New supplier connections expand access to foreign varieties and quality, but the additional information about supplier trustworthiness is necessary for building lasting and profitable relationships. Structural estimates imply that both adverse selection and moral hazard substantially limit trade.

Quantifying the Sensitivity of Quantitative Trade Models (with Habib Chenguiti Ansari and Dave Donaldson)

The core ingredient of modern quantitative trade models is cross-country heterogeneity in productive capabilities across goods. In workhorse models this heterogeneity is assumed to follow specific functional forms—such as i.i.d. Frechet or Pareto—but little is known about how these models' counterfactual predictions would change under alternative distributional assumptions. We fill this gap by estimating sharp bounds on counterfactuals across all distributions within given neighborhoods of the workhorse model. Importantly, our method only considers distributions that can generate baseline equilibria that exactly match all trade flow data points, and hence reproduce empirical facts such as the amount of openness, the fit of the gravity equation, and the estimated trade elasticity. Our estimated bounds on the gains from trade are wide, even for small departures from the workhorse model: the upper bound is more than four times that of the workhorse model (so trade can be much more valuable than typically thought) and the lower bound is zero (so trade can even generate no gains). Imposing high-level restrictions on the distributions considered—for example, maintaining Frechet/Pareto marginals but relaxing independence, or vice versa—does little to shrink these bounds.

Publications

Losing Prosociality in the Quest for Talent? Sorting, Selection, and Productivity in the Delivery of Public Services (with Nava Ashraf, Oriana Bandiera, and Scott S. Lee)
American Economic Review 2020, 110(5): 1355-1394
Awarded the Arrow Award for the best paper published in health economics in English in 2020, from the International Health Economics Association

We embed a field experiment in a nationwide recruitment drive for a new health care position in Zambia to test whether career benefits attract talent at the expense of prosocial motivation. In line with common wisdom, offering career opportunities attracts less prosocial applicants. However, the trade-off exists only at low levels of talent; the marginal applicants in treatment are more talented and equally prosocial. These are hired, and perform better at every step of the causal chain: they provide more inputs, increase facility utilization, and improve health outcomes including a 25 percent decrease in child malnutrition.

Select Work in Progress

Using Digital Records to Unlock Trade Credit: Evidence from Cote d'Ivoire (with Deivy Houeix)

Trade credit—suppliers allowing buyers to purchase inventory now and pay later—is central to firm-to-firm commerce but depends on trust. In settings with limited contract enforcement, suppliers often ration credit to unfamiliar buyers, limiting firm growth and creating barriers to entry. We study whether firms can use increasingly available mobile payments records to signal creditworthiness to potential suppliers or lenders—an open finance model—and how this affects relationship development and firm- and market-level outcomes. We collaborate with a large mobile money provider in Cote d'Ivoire to build and evaluate a tool for firms to provided verified disclosures, as well as a fintech specializing in trade credit to study how specialized intermediaries use such records. We run an RCT with 2,000 retailers in the packaged drinks sector, where we randomize whether firms can access the new disclosure tool and whether we connect them with the specialized trade credit lender. Pilot results show that the ability to do verified disclosures increases supplier willingness to extend credit by 20 percentage points. The full RCT is active, with outcomes of interest including credit access, supplier relationships, product varieties, prices, stockouts, and profits and sales.

Fellowships, Honors, and Awards

TA of the Year Award (Undergraduate Economics Association, MIT)	2023-2024
Graduate Student Council Teaching Award (awarded to 5 TAs or professors MIT-wide)	2021-2022

Global Priorities Fellowship (University of Oxford)	2020-2022
Arrow Award (International Health Economics Association)	2020
Kennedy Scholarship (national merit scholarship awarded to ∼10 UK nationals per year)	2019-2020
John Hicks Prize (ranked first in LSE MSc Economics)	2018

Conference and Workshop Presentations

NBER International Trade and Investment, Fall Meeting [scheduled]	2026
Conference on Urban and Regional Economics (Columbia Business School) [scheduled]	2026
NBER Summer Institute, Development Economics	2026
Theoretical Research in Economic Development (Geneva School of Economics)	2026
IGC/EGC Conference on Firms, Trade, and Development (Yale University)	2025
Institutions, Trade and Economic Development Workshop (University of Alberta)	2025
NBER Summer Institute, International Trade and Investment	2025
Northeastern Universities Development Consortium (NEUDC)	2024
Cities and Development Workshop (Harvard University)	2024
Junior Trade Workshop (LSE-Warwick)	2024

Research Grants

PEDL (£14,600) (with V. Bassi, D. Houeix, M. Keenan)	2025
PEDL (£19,500) (with D. Houeix)	2025
IGC (£18,561) (with D. Houeix)	2025
International Science Partnerships Fund (£99,866) (with N. Ashraf, O. Bandiera, V. Mukonka)	2024
IGC (£19,981) (with N. Ashraf and O. Bandiera)	2024
Shultz Fund, MIT ($15,833.33) (with D. Houeix)	2024
IGC (£20,000) (with N. Ashraf and O. Bandiera)	2023
PEDL (£31,000) (with D. Houeix)	2023
PEDL (£20,720) (with T. Garg)	2023
Shultz Fund, MIT ($14,251.67) (with D. Houeix)	2023
Shultz Fund, MIT ($14,982.76) (with D. Houeix)	2022
Shultz Fund, MIT ($6,000) (with T. Garg)	2022
STEG (£11,960) (with T. Garg)	2021
Shultz Fund, MIT ($12,000) (with I. Puri)	2020
IGC (£9,346) (with N. Ashraf)	2019

Referee Activity

American Economic Review, Econometrica, Economica, Journal of Development Economics, Journal of Economic Behavior and Organization, Journal of Political Economy, Labour Economics, Quarterly Journal of Economics

Other Working Experience

Currency Derivative Structuring, Deutsche Bank, London	2015-2017

Personal Details

Languages: English (Native), French (Fluent)
Citizenship: UK, Canada